

Ananias and Sapphira: Truth Before God

By Dn Yonnas · Scripture · Youth & Young Adults

Summary

An in-depth reading of Acts 5:1-11 for the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo youth. Why did so severe a judgment fall on Ananias and Sapphira at the very birth of the Church? The reading shows that their sin was not keeping their money but lying to the Holy Spirit — and that Peter's words, "You have not lied to men but to God," are one of Scripture's clearest witnesses that the Holy Spirit is truly God. It calls us to truthfulness, to giving from love rather than show, and to the holy fear of God.

Lesson Objectives

- Tell the story of Ananias and Sapphira accurately from Acts 5
- Explain that their sin was hypocrisy and lying to the Holy Spirit, not the keeping of their property
- Show from Peter's words that the Holy Spirit is truly God
- Learn to love the truth, to give in secret from the heart, and to live in the holy fear of God

Key Bible Verses

Acts 5:3-4 — "Why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit?... You have not lied to men but to God."

Acts 5:11 — "So great fear came upon all the church and upon all who heard these things."

Proverbs 9:10 — "The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom."

Matthew 6:3-4 — "Do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing... and your Father who sees in secret will reward you openly."

Main Teaching Points

- The early Church in Jerusalem shared everything in love (koinonia); Ananias and Sapphira broke that trust
- Their property and money were their own — they were not required to sell or to give all (Acts 5:4)
- Their sin was hypocrisy and lying to the Holy Spirit, driven by love of money and love of human praise (vainglory)
- Satan 'filled their heart' because they made room for him; the responsibility remained theirs
- "You have not lied to men but to God" shows that the Holy Spirit is truly God — a witness to the Holy Trinity
- God acted visibly at the Church's foundation so that all would learn the holy fear of God
- Scripture leaves their eternal fate to God's mercy; the warning is for us, not a verdict on them
- The Sacrament of Confession is the honest path they refused — we tell the truth and receive life

Key Terms

- **Koinonia** — Holy communion or fellowship — the shared life of love in the early Church, where believers held all things in common (Acts 4:32).
- **Hypocrisy** — Wearing a holy mask over an unholy heart; performing devotion outwardly while the inner reality is different. The central sin of Ananias and Sapphira.
- **Vainglory** — The hunger to be seen and praised by people. It drove the lie, as they wanted the honor of total sacrifice without the reality.

- **Holy fear of God** — Reverent awe before the living and holy God — not the terror of a slave, but the beginning of wisdom (Proverbs 9:10).
- **The Holy Spirit** — The Third Person of the Holy Trinity, true God, 'the Lord, the Giver of Life'; to lie to Him is to lie to God (Acts 5:3-4).

Discussion & Reflection

- Peter says the land and money were their own. So what exactly was their sin?
- How do verses 3 and 4 together teach us that the Holy Spirit is God?
- What is the difference between holy fear of God and being simply afraid of God?
- Where are we tempted to 'look more devout than we are'? How does Confession heal that?
- Barnabas and Ananias did almost the same outward action. What made them so different inside?

Debre Nazreth St. Mary & St. Gabriel Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church — STL Theology Class
Glory be to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit, one God. Amen.